

A ROYAL TREAT

Patrons being treated to barbecued delights; (far left) a lake-view room at the WelcomHeritage Cheetahgarh Resort & Spa, Bera

her shoulder in elegant profile, alert but relaxed. Bhawani is a bit of a stan account as far as Neelam goes. I'm later told a story about how he once left a great sighting and inexplicably parked somewhere else. Soon enough, Neelam walked away from all the jeeps, came straight to Bhawani's spot, and gave his guests a fabulous private sighting. He knows this leopard. He loves her. She's the wallpaper on his phone.

He tells me she has a seven-month-old cub. A female will mate with lots of males, including her sons, but retains some control over which will impregnate her. It's called false mating, and is designed to fool each male into thinking the cubs might be his, so that he doesn't kill them. There was a report the previous night that she may have suffered a minor injury, but, I venture, she seems fine. Bhawani, misty-eyed, replies, "She's perfect."

At the resort, I step into Svasti Spa for a deep tissue massage and a sauna. Then to the restaurant for a fantastic gazpacho and salad lunch with the affable general manager, Karan Bakshi, who gives the impression of a man who has never met a problem he couldn't solve. He tells me that resort owners are trying to self-regulate so that there aren't too many jeeps in the area at one time, and the star attraction can flourish in peace. The restaurant has a wide selection of cuisines, but he says he's taking me somewhere special for dinner.

There's high tea for guests in the restaurant (no room service, so don't ask) but I prefer to watch clouds scud over the lake.

In the evening, Bhawani races up a massive rock *in reverse* and I get a bird's-eye view of the Aravali hills, of russet rock and *anwal* (*Senna auriculata*) bushes with bright yellow